1. Ask a factual question about India in English.
2. Ask the same question in Hindi or your preferred Indian language.
3. Ask it again in natural Hinglish or transliterated text.
4. Give the model a paragraph containing Indian names, places and rupee values and ask for a summary.
5. Ask it to translate a colloquial sentence rather than formal textbook prose.

Judge fluency, factual accuracy and whether the output sounds natural. A model that wins an English benchmark but mangles your everyday language is not your best model.

Step 8: Read the licence before falling in love

"Downloadable" does not mean "do whatever you want".

Some model families use permissive licences such as Apache 2.0. gpt-oss, Mistral Small 4, Gemma 4 and Qwen3.6-35B-A3B are current examples carrying Apache 2.0 terms.

Meta's Llama 4 models instead use the Llama 4 Community License Agreement. Other repositories may impose non-commercial restrictions, attribution conditions or restrictions inherited from datasets and derivatives.

For personal experimentation this may not change much today. It matters enormously if you later build a commercial app, redistribute weights or use the model inside a business.

Your shortlist should therefore include a licence column. If you cannot explain what the licence permits, do not assume.

Step 9: Check runtime support before downloading 20GB

A brilliant model that your software cannot load is just an expensive SSD ornament.

Look at the model card and your runtime's model catalogue before downloading. gpt-oss, for instance, launched with support across tools including Ollama, llama.cpp and LM Studio. Qwen3.6's model card lists Transformers, vLLM, SGLang and other frameworks.

For beginner use, availability in GGUF or directly through LM Studio/Ollama can be more important than winning another percentage point on a benchmark.

Also check whether the exact quantisation you need exists. A 30B model with no practical format for your machine should not stay on the shortlist simply because somebody posted a glowing review.

Benchmarks are auditions, not employment contracts

Model makers publish benchmark tables because standardised tests are useful. They let you compare reasoning, maths, coding, multilingual performance and other capabilities under defined conditions.

BUILD YOUR THREE-MODEL SHORTLIST

You are now ready to choose candidates. Do this before downloading anything large.

Create three slots:

FAST: the smallest model that performs your everyday jobs well.

SMART: the strongest model your machine can run at a speed you can tolerate.

SPECIALIST: coding, vision, translation or Indian-language capability that your other two do not cover well.

For each candidate record:

- Model and exact variant
- Task
- Total and active parameters
- Quantisation
- Expected file size
- Context window
- Text/vision/audio support
- Supported languages
- Licence
- Runtime compatibility
- Why you chose it

Do not declare a winner yet.

They are not your workload.

Scores can depend on prompting, evaluation settings, quantisation, model version and whether a benchmark resembles training material. More importantly, a model can perform brilliantly on mathematical reasoning while being awkward at the writing style you need.

Use benchmarks to eliminate obviously weak candidates and identify promising ones. Then test the finalists yourself.

Take ten prompts from your real life: a troublesome spreadsheet formula, a paragraph you frequently rewrite, an Indian-language query, a coding bug, a document summary, a hallucination trap and a reasoning question. Run exactly the same prompts through each shortlisted model with similar settings.

Record four things: quality, speed, memory use and consistency.

The result may surprise you. Your favourite model may not be the largest one. It may not be the newest. It may even lose most public leaderboard comparisons.

But if it fits your computer, responds quickly, handles your language, follows your instructions and produces the best answers for the work you actually do, then you have found something much more useful than "the best model". You have found the right model.